

Week 5: Plot in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Every scene in the Bible sits inside a bigger story — tonight we'll look at how paying attention to that changes what a passage means.

1. Have you ever badly misread a movie or book because you only caught one scene out of context — like walking into a film halfway through? What happened once you finally saw the whole thing?
2. The video walked through the whole Gideon story in Judges 6-7. Before we go further: in that story, where do you think the *real* conflict actually sits? Not "how will Gideon win the battle," but what tension does the narrator seem most interested in — and where does it get resolved, if it does?
3. **Read Judges 8:22-31.** After the famous victory, Gideon gives the theologically correct answer — "I will not rule over you... the LORD will rule over you" (v. 23) — and then immediately makes a gold ephod that becomes "a snare to Gideon and to his household," and names a son Abimelech, which means "my father is king." What has happened to Gideon by the end of his own story? Does his ending change how you read the victory that came before it?
4. Some readers sort biblical plots into a "comedy" shape (a flawed character is humbled and then rises) or a "tragedy" shape (a character with every advantage slowly self-destructs). Looking at the whole span of Judges 6-8, which shape fits Gideon best — and what's your evidence?
5. **Read Jonah 3.** (Quick recap: Jonah has run from God's call to preach against Nineveh, been thrown overboard and swallowed by a great fish, and been given a second chance.) Imagine the book ended right here — as more than one children's Bible actually does. What would the story be about, and what would you take away from it?
6. **Read Jonah 4.** What does this final chapter reveal the book was really about all along? Skim back over chapter 1 — how does Jonah's behavior there read differently now?

7. Judges ends by repeating, four times, "In those days there was no king in Israel" — twice adding, "everyone did what was right in his own eyes." If Gideon is one of the *better* judges, what is the book as a whole building toward? How does that larger arc change what the Gideon story is "about"?
8. **Read 1 Samuel 8:4-9.** The book of Judges seems to be reaching for a king — but when Israel finally demands one, God's answer to Samuel is "they have rejected me from being king over them," and he grants the request anyway. The kings that follow mostly fail, David included. So the thing Judges wants turns out to be part of the problem, not the fix. Pulling back to the whole Bible: what kind of leadership does the story actually turn out to need?
9. This week's podcast compares misreading a story to hiking toward what looks like the summit — then realizing it was a false peak on a much bigger climb. Has that happened in your own life: something you read at the time as the end of the story — a peak, or a defeat — that turned out to be the middle of something larger?
10. Think of a familiar Bible story you've mostly encountered in bite-sized pieces — a sermon point, a devotional, a kids' Bible version. What might change if you read the whole surrounding narrative in one sitting instead?